



Up against the best: Popularly known as the 'Indo-Pak Express', Qureshi's pairing with Rohan Bopanna was one of his major career highlights. They reached the summit clash of the 2010 US Open where they lost to the Bryan twins after stretching them to tiebreaks in both sets. GETTY IMAGES

our times, our federation never tried. So, I don't want my players to suffer. As part of the MoU, our players will travel to these countries and train," Qureshi says, making it clear that the ATF 12&U Team Competition – South Asia, to be played in Islamabad in May, is also a step in the right direction.

After taking over as president of the federation, Qureshi has roped in quite a few international coaches and trainers, including Eduardo Vicencio Lalovic, and has also improved the facilities. "A year ago, we didn't have shower rooms, proper lockers, or a cafeteria, but now we have everything in place. The idea is to acknowledge the efforts of the players and respect

them. If we don't respect them enough by providing basic facilities, how can we expect them to perform well? So, that's my priority," he says.

While Qureshi the administrator has set his priorities right, Qureshi the player, too, has set a few targets. He wants to bow out from professional tennis after donning the Pakistan colours for one last time at the South Asian Games, scheduled to be held across Lahore, Faisalabad and Islamabad in January next year.

In his long and illustrious career, Qureshi has won 18 titles, but one of his major career highlights was pairing with Rohan Bopanna. In fact, he and Bopanna reached the summit clash at the US Open in 2010 as the last seeded pair. Popularly known as the 'Indo-Pak Express', the pair was up against top seeds and arguably the greatest doubles team of all time — Mike and Bob Bryan. The two 30-year-olds stretched the twins to tiebreaks in both sets before going down 7-6(5), 7-6(4).

For Qureshi, though, the biggest

moment with Bopanna was winning their first ATP World Tour doubles title at the South African Open in 2010, defeating Karol Beck and Harel Levy in the final. "We were winning Challengers until then in singles, but we decided to give it a shot in doubles and once we started, we had our moments of glory," he says. "I remember travelling to Bengaluru to train with Bops for a few weeks. Purav Raja and Mustafa Ghouse were also part of the training. That was a great experience, and during our partnership, we made so many memories. But of course, winning the first ATP title and a Grand Slam will always remain special..."

Qureshi has teamed up with several other Indian players, including Leander Paes, with whom he has fond memories. "If you look at my entire career, I've played with so many Indian players. It was the easiest thing when you were on the tour. The language is the same, the culture is the same, you get to spend so much time off the court, on the court, and in such times, those